

Fiction

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Creative Writing

Up In Ashes

Lily had entered the Roosevelt Hotel with a passion only somebody who knew grief personally could muster, and she had walked with the experience of a thousand doors slamming. Her posture had been horrible, her shoulders slouched forward, and her neck, though long, had always portrayed itself unusually and unnaturally forward. She didn't have much luggage with her, just two powder blue cases. She wore sunglasses that covered the majority of her face, and a cigarette hung out of the corner of her pink-stained lips. She had been wearing a peacoat and had flipped the collar up against her neck, probably in a vain attempt to keep out the wind. A prominent bump stuck out of her jacket as she walked, offsetting her balance as though it was something new to her. Lily had dropped her bags in front of the reception desk, leaned over the side, grabbed a key, left a twenty on the marble counter, picked up her bags, and headed towards the elevator. Her shoes echoed against the polished wood, and she didn't take a moment to look around her, though what a sight it was. The ceilings of the lobby arched and bowed in an alluring charm, and the chandeliers chimed in the wind when a force pushed the revolving doors a slight too quick. The concierge wore a bright red suit with golden lapels, not a strand out of place. When Lily had entered, he had been talking to an older woman holding a small white dog; she had been complaining about the cold weather, while the boy nodded along in faux empathy. Gaudy displays of wealth surrounded the large interior, demonstrated heavily by a man smoking a Montecristo that sat in a large velvet chair, reading the paper in the languor of the small atmosphere around him. A couple waited at the front desk, checking their watches every few minutes, the man sighing impatiently now and then. While bell boys bustled around the squeaky floors and laughs rose with smoke, the newcomer had closed herself in the elevator. The only word Lily had said that afternoon was "twelve" after being requested her floor.

When the elevator opened its heavy gold doors, Lily, who hadn't let go of her luggage on the short lift up strode easily out and slipped the operator a nickel. Only when she had reached her room did

she take off her sunglasses and throw her bags on the bed. The cigarette had burned quickly, the ashes caking at the end until a soft powder fell on the bedspread. Lily hadn't bothered to clean them up. The room was quiet. She crossed to the window and pulled the curtains aside, tugging against the fragile rod until the curtains stayed behind the hook on the wall. She stared down at the traffic below her, squinting in the gray sunlight. She watched a group of women walking with haughty importance, and she watched the doorman take off his cap to wave it at someone across the street. Lily turned from the window and trilled her lips at the room, she began to pace. The cigarette had lost its glow and she was acutely aware of that as the hot ash kissed her bottom lip, she spat the butt quickly into the ashtray and stared down at the remains, a defeated whimper escaped her mouth. Lily stood vacantly at the end of the bed, pressed the heels of her palms into her eyes, and shook her head. A curtain fell from its hook and she snapped her neck back up, eyes blurred and red from rubbing. Her makeup had been smudged and one of her lips was slightly burnt in one place. Her bags were laying heavy on the duvet cover, and the yellowing walls around Lily seemed to shrink around her. She stuck her hand in her coat pockets, feeling every corner but came out empty. She then dumped the contents of both suitcases onto the floor and sifted through the pile of clothes. A soft vanilla and cinnamon scent began to soak through everything as she sat defeatedly on the ground and Lily knew that she had broken her perfume bottle. She put one hand on the floor, the other on her swelling stomach, and stood up. She kicked the now-soaked clothes into the corner of the room, but then kicked the suitcases against the wall with them for good measure. As the fermented scent sank itself into the carpet Lily began to cry, she really did use to love that smell but now it burned a sickly sweet slap through her nose and into her lungs. Lily needed another cigarette.

Jack was brilliant, he was a creator of dreams and he seemed to hold each endless opportunity in his soft hands. He had come from a family of wealth, everybody had known, but he remained humble in every circumstance. He had never fallen in love before but he had always imagined it would be his biggest accomplishment. He was never satisfied in much of anything that he did, and every small victory was only a mere step towards some goal only he could see. So when Lily had met this boy on a field trip her senior year for her French class to the local movie theater, (it was to see a documentary called *A*

propos de Nice), the both of them left with a different spirit. Jack was astounded by Lily's easygoing humor and beauty, Lily had seen Jack's potential and his lovely face. After that day, still in college, Jack would wait for Lily in his shining car outside of the town High School for her, and Lily bought a nicer pair of shoes. She began to hang around him everywhere, skipping class and crawling out of her first-floor window into the night, her parents didn't mind, and barely objected when she told them she was leaving for Los Angeles. They were thrilled really, they were happy she had found a boy who could take care of her and settle down, maybe have a family someday. Lily had packed one bag with most of her favorite belongings and hopped on a train with Jack the next morning. She had slept on his shoulder for most of the ride, hand in hand, and Jack was content. He had his share of worries as anyone does when moving across the country, but at that moment he felt right with Lily by his side.

As the pair settled into their new town, they married at the City Hall, rented out a small apartment across from the Brighton Coffee Shop, and fell even more in love. Lily got a job at the cross street business, and Jack began collecting newspapers feverishly circling job opportunities, then leaving at strange hours of the day for an interview. He applied at two publishing companies, three accounting jobs, and several others that Lily eventually forgot about. In the following April, Jack found a position as an assistant to the current head of MGM in Hollywood, he was offered the job immediately. Lily dropped one of her shifts. Jack began to take Lily out for dinners, and began buying new throw pillows, he began taking Lily dancing. She started to spend more money on groceries and getting her hair done often.

On a Monday one July, the pair was walking on the warm sands of a beach shoes hanging off of hooked fingers, left hand in right.

"Jack," Lily had started, "where do you see yourself in ten years?" Jack didn't even hesitate.

"With you," and he squeezed her hand. Lily had smiled, but she wasn't happy, of course, she wanted to be with him but she didn't expect his only priority to be her. Lily had always taken things seriously, this was an unsatisfactory answer and it felt like a lie. Lily asked him again,

"Seriously, Jack, what are you going to do with your life?" Now Jack was the unhappy one, he didn't like to be rushed, or seen as incompetent, a constant battle he fought with himself.

“Successful.” He replied, after more time squinting in the direction of the sun. “Successful and happy.” Lily didn’t prod for more, but she had wished he’d had a plan.

A few summers later, as Jack began to climb the ladder at the producing company, Lily began to see less and less of him. He had begun to try his hand at auditions, parts that could guide him to something big, and one day it finally happened. Jack earned the role of a leading man in an upcoming Cukor film. Lily and Jack had celebrated that night with expensive champagne and oysters at a restaurant on the water.

“Lily,” Jack had said that night, “you are my inspiration, my joy, and my better half.” Then they touched their glasses together in a small toast.

A year later, the movie had released and it was a hit. Jack was already signing contracts for enticing new projects as Lily found herself attending more and more parties. She enjoyed it at first, but as the numbers kept rising and the champagne became less of a treat, she grew tired. She grew lonely in rooms full of people, most she didn’t know but had seen pour their hearts to her several times larger than their size. At one particular party, held at the home of some actress, Lily sat at a long oak table sipping an Old Fashioned and laughing politely as the hostess barked at her own jokes, enjoying herself very much. As the night was reaching the point of heavy eyes and slurred talk, Lily rose to get air. She had sluggishly slipped through conversations to the door and inhaled deeply in the bright evening. It had been a beautiful scene, every star was visible and every home was illuminated in warm yellow, tossed across a pile of hills. Thinking she was alone in this serenity, Lily leaned against the rail of the balcony and pressed her head against her forearms.

“Not having fun?” A voice rose out of the silken evening. Lily startled and fixed her posture.

“I’m just fine.” She had replied and turned to go back inside.

“Here doll, this will help,” before she could reach for the door, a young man had reached out and a cigarette butt glowed orange in front of her. She looked down at the tinged paper and back to the man, one eyebrow raised.

“I don’t smoke, but thank you,” she replied coolly.

“Everybody smokes.” He had replied. Lily looked him over, he had been in Jack’s movie, he did alright. But the night was clear, and maybe it was the lonesome ache she could never seem to keep down or the bubbles of a thousand glasses of champagne from a thousand parties. Either way, Lily gave in.

“Fine.” She took the cigarette, trying to ignore the stare her husband was giving the pair through the glass door, breathed in the bitter smoke, and promptly threw up.

Lily was pregnant, and she had been for a few weeks. Jack was thrilled, and Lily found herself enjoying a new angle of life. On a cold evening, wrapped in a shawl, Lily sat smoking, a new habit of hers, and Jack sat with a whiskey. Lily had asked,

“What should we name them?” and smiled at her hand that rested on her growing belly.

“Benjamin,” Jack replied after a moment of contemplation.

“Like your father,” Lily smiled, “very sweet.” Jack had smiled back at her.

“But what if they’re a girl?”

“Then you decide.” He replied, setting his now empty glass on the table. He made the motion to get up and refill it, but Lily cleared her throat.

“Jack, I don’t want you drinking so much anymore.” Her eyes remained intent on the wooden surface in front of her. Jack paused, halfway out of his seat. His eyebrows furrowed, creating uneven lines on his face that Lily had only seen on screen.

“I don’t drink that much,” he answered and proceeded to get up.

“That’s going to be your fourth tonight.” Lily was more defiant now and she put the cigarette out in her ashtray.

“So? That was *your* third.” His eyes were growing icy, he had never been in favor of Lily smoking, even though everyone else really did do it. Lily pursed her lips and stared at her husband with a knot in her chest, she could feel the unease in the air.

“Please.” She sighed in little more than a whisper. She reached out to hold his hand onto her stomach. Jack’s eyes grew soft at this, and he set his glass on the table.

“Alright.” Lily inhaled the warm smell of Jack into her chest, fresh laundry soap and cologne weaved together with makeup from set and stale gin as she hugged his strong frame.

Lily went to the kitchen to clean up, and Jack poured another glass before he slipped up the stairs to take a bath. When Lily had gone back to clear the table and didn’t see Jack’s glass, she threw every bottle of alcohol in the house from the second-floor bedroom window, cursing under her breath with each one. Jack had been furious, he had said they were expensive drinks, Lily had said he cared more for them than his child. Jack had slapped her, and Lily put her cigarette out on his hand. Jack apologized and bought Lily a bouquet of flowers. This only began the series of quarrels that would steal the shine from Jack’s eyes and make Lily rarely leave the house. Of course, they would always resolve whatever would come up with pink carnations, whether it be who their child’s godparents were, how long Lily would spend in the shower, or how many times empty bottles were found hidden under the full trash bags.

When Lily was seven months, she didn’t feel quite like going to parties anymore, she felt like laying in bed with a warm compress reading a book, so she did just that. While Jack was out with costars and new friends, Lily lay in the silence of her large home. She never liked being there alone, and she found herself humming herself to sleep to fill the silence of the place her husband once lay. Lily would have dreams of Jack holding her in the dark of their first apartment, she would dream of stealing sips of stale coffee during breaks. Her mind would drift to home, and to Jack at the movie theater counter, she would often wake smiling before the white walls hugging her abrasively and the hungover snores of Jack truly woke her up.

On a warm September morning, Lily woke to an empty bed, made all the more obvious by the silence of the room around her, only a bird sang a good morning through the curtained windows. She had slowly gotten up, ignoring the pain in her back, and descended to the kitchen. The light beat against the blue walls, and there was a still breath in the air- as if a white lie had just been told. Lily poured herself a cup of coffee, and sat alone at the table, in the silence, in the emptiness. At half-past noon, Jack walked through the door, a bouquet of carnations tucked under his arm, Lily had dozed off at the table but woke to the sound of the door unlocking. Jack walked over to her and set the flowers by her folded arms.

“Good morning.” He kissed her on the top of her head and poured himself a cup of coffee, splashing a bit of something in his.

“Jack you can’t be serious.” Lily glared at his hand putting the small flask back into his coat pocket. “You smell bad too,” she remarked.

“Just for you,” he joked and smothered her in a hug.

“What is up with you?” Lily had to suppress a smile, she chose to ignore his mug, she had missed him.

“Can’t a man just love his wife?” He had asked, pressing another kiss on her head. Lily leaned into him and smiled into his collar, she had longed for this moment even in sleep. She hummed against him as a deep stench of floral perfume and powder hit her nose. She pulled back slowly, before leaning in and smelling again.

“What were you doing out all night?” She asked him, her eyes large and entirely focused on his own. Jack moved into the kitchen, sifting the counters for the sugar packets.

“Just lost track of time, you know how I am.” He had smiled quickly and took a sip of his coffee looking away from his wife, staring directly at the steaming drink. Jack had never been a good liar. It was funny to Lily at that moment that he had decided to be an actor and succeeded. A laugh escaped her lips and Jack looked at her worried. She looked down at his hands where his wedding band had been put on only to the knuckle, quietly in haste. Maybe in a car, or maybe a hotel room, never his own bed.

“Obviously I don’t because you have never once gotten *carried away* until noon.” Lily was standing now, nostrils flaring. He knew that she knew.

“Lily- I’m so sorry-”

“*Carnations?* This whole time... You are so dense,” Lily exclaimed in shock then in realization. She had picked up the bouquet and shook them in his face. “You are horrible.” She threw them at his feet, and petals scattered around their shoes. Her eyes were full of tears now, and she could feel her patience about to snap with a handful of her nerves.

“Lily please.” Jack reached out and tried to hold her hands, she shook him off.

“How long? How long Jack?” She had asked, her voice growing to a high falsetto. Jack looked down.

“Two months.” Two months for Lily to make a fool of herself. Two months for Jack to lose the one thing Lily was sure he could never have again.

“Ohhh, oh no.” She groaned and tears slipped down her face reluctantly. “I’m leaving.” A husky voice now left her lips, she wrapped her arms protectively around her waist.

“Lily don’t, you know that would be a mistake,” he paused, “where else do you have to go anyways?” Jack stood dejectedly in the kitchen as Lily began backing away from him.

“Somewhere. I don’t know. Anywhere but, but here, I don’t know.” She wiped her face with one hand and turned up the stairs. She packed two suitcases and threw a coat over her nightdress. When Lily walked out the door, all she said was: “You would have been a poor excuse for a dad anyway.”

Jack had smashed a glass and cut his hand, he stood over the sink running his bleeding hand under the tap water as Lily started his car, Jack didn’t cry. Lily wasn’t leaving a man who had broken her heart, she was leaving a side of her life that had never fully belonged to just her.

So on that distant night in Los Angeles, Lily stood in her quiet hotel room over a pile of clothes she had bought in the prime of her first, and only, love and she cried. She cried for the days she had wasted, and the nights she had ignored. She cried for her heart, and she cried for the times she had told herself he had really loved her. She cried for her child. Lily abandoned the stolen air and went to the bathroom where she locked the door and drew a bath. She let the water grow hot enough to fill the air with steam so thick it felt sickening to breathe. She imagined it was the stale smoke lingering in her old home, her heart and mind ached for at least one consistency. Lily sunk into the water and buried her head in the stillness, she blew bubbles out until she could no longer hold her lungs so still and burst to gasp for air into the clouded room. She felt her hair stick to her cheeks but didn’t attempt to fix it. Lily let her heavy head slide back on the porcelain rim of the bath and cried again.